

Reading beats writing now.

The technical interview is quietly changing. Here's why it should.

A few large companies are reportedly grading code reading, not code writing.

Reading and debugging an existing codebase, with an AI assistant available — instead of writing from a blank file.

*Per a few interview-prep sources I've read.
Not a round I've sat myself.*

Two different skills.

WRITING FROM SCRATCH

Rewards recall.

Syntax, algorithms, a solution shape held in your head.

READING + VERIFYING

Rewards judgment.

Holding someone else's logic fast enough to catch what's wrong.

**An assistant can write
a working function in
seconds now.**

**It still can't tell you
whether what it wrote
is actually correct.**

Closer to the actual job.

PR review. A diff. A service
someone else wrote 6 months ago.

FEWER blank-file algorithm drills.

MORE **“find the bug in this file.”**

Writing-from-scratch was always
a slightly artificial proxy for
what backend engineers actually do.

I'd take this interview over the whiteboard version any day.

**Not because it's easier.
Because it's closer to
the real job.**

Have you sat a comprehension-style round? What did it feel like against the classic algorithm interview?